



your hypnobirthing handbook

for caesarean



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why caesarean?

A caesarean birth is not a failure, a shortcut, or “the easy way out.” It is major surgery, yes, but it is also a powerful, valid way to bring your baby into the world and a deeply personal birth experience. For some families, a caesarean is planned in advance; for others, it becomes the safest choice during labour or pregnancy. Many parents feel a mix of emotions, relief, grief, excitement, or disappointment, and all of these are normal and valid.

What matters most is not how your baby arrives, but that you feel informed, respected, and supported throughout.

Caesareans happen for many reasons: baby’s position, placenta concerns, multiples, previous caesarean, maternal health, or sometimes personal choice. Some are planned calmly; others happen more urgently. Both are real births and both deserve preparation.

Not all caesareans are the same, some are planned, some unplanned, some urgent, and some can even be “gentle caesareans,” where the birth is slowed and personalised to support connection and bonding.

A caesarean is major surgery and carries risks: longer recovery, more pain, risk of infection or bleeding, and potential impact on future pregnancies. It can also affect you emotionally, especially if the birth feels out of your control. Knowing this does not create fear, it gives you the power to make informed choices and prepare fully.

Even in surgery, you have rights, you have the right to clear information, consent before procedures, respectful communication, a partner present where safe, and choices about atmosphere, bonding, and feeding. Skin to skin, early feeding, and emotional support are all possible, and your voice still matters.

Planning a caesarean is not about controlling everything.

It is about understanding your options, clarifying what matters to you, and creating a sense of agency in a situation that can otherwise feel overwhelming. When you plan, you move from “this is happening to me” to “I am part of this.” You are not just a patient, you are a birthing parent, and your caesarean birth deserves just as much intention, respect, and tenderness as any other birth.

caesarean birth: understanding the risks

A caesarean is major surgery, and like any operation, it carries risks. But knowing these risks helps you make informed choices, feel prepared, and advocate for your care. Most caesareans — whether planned or emergency — result in healthy parents and babies, especially when the surgery is well-managed and supported.

Maternal Risks

- Even in a planned caesarean, there are some risks to be aware of:
- Wound or uterine infection: slightly higher after emergency procedures.
- Excessive bleeding: sometimes requiring a blood transfusion.
- Blood clots: slightly increased risk compared with vaginal birth.
- Damage to nearby organs: such as the bladder or ureters (rare).
- Longer recovery: caesareans usually take several weeks to fully heal.
- Impact on future pregnancies: slightly higher risk of uterine rupture (~1 in 500), placenta previa, or placenta accreta (~1 in 1,000) compared with parents who have only had vaginal births.
- Emergency caesareans carry higher maternal complication rates than planned ones, including infection, blood loss, and longer hospital stays.

Neonatal (Baby) Risks

- Babies born via caesarean are generally healthy, but there are some differences compared with vaginal birth:
- Breathing or respiratory difficulties: more common if the baby is born before labour or before 39 weeks.
- Emergency C-sections: up to 18% of babies experience mild respiratory issues.
- Elective C-sections at term: around 5%.
- Neonatal intensive care (NICU) admission: slightly higher after emergency caesareans.
- Lower Apgar scores at birth: occasionally reported in emergency situations.
- Planning your caesarean around 39 weeks can help reduce some of these risks.

Outcome	Planned Caesarean	Vaginal Birth
Maternal death	~1 in 4,000	~1 in 25,000
Uterine rupture (future pregnancy)	~1 in 500	~1 in 14,000
Placenta accreta (future pregnancy)	~1 in 1,000	~1 in 2,900
Neonatal death (within 28 days)	~58 per 100,000	~30 per 100,000

These numbers show relative risk, but most caesareans result in healthy outcomes, especially when planned and medically supervised.

WHY THESE NUMBERS MATTER, BUT DON'T DEFINE YOUR BIRTH

Knowledge is power. Understanding risks allows you to prepare physically and emotionally.

Most complications are rare, and most babies do very well after caesarean birth.

Emergency caesareans naturally carry higher risks because they are performed due to complications — the risks are not caused by the surgery itself.

Being informed means you can plan for comfort, bonding, and emotional connection, making your birth positive and empowering, even in surgery.

Bottom Line

A caesarean is a safe and valid way to give birth. Being aware of risks allows you to make choices that protect you and your baby, while still reclaiming this as your birth. With preparation, planning, and support, you can experience a calm, connected, and empowering caesarean birth, every bit as meaningful as any other way of welcoming your baby.

How does this make you feel?

wtf is hypnobirthing?

The chances are you know what hypnobirthing is at this point. Let's sum it up below just to be sure and to help explain to partners, family or friends who may think it's a load of rubbish!

So here it is!

It's getting informed about birth- It's learning all about the process of birth, the hormones involved, how to choose your birth place, how your environment can help you to feel positive and help the process along, the role of the birth partner, the stages of labour, positions to help aid baby's position, how to write a birth plan and all sorts of other stuff that if you haven't been at loads of births (and most of us haven't) you just won't know unless you've been told it or sought it out. The more you know about birth, the more likely it is that you will feel prepared to face it yourself.

It's a change of mindset- Knowing what the body is doing and HOW can really help you to see birth as a positive thing and take a lot of the fear away. Between getting as informed as possible and taking in lots of positive information about birth, you can completely change your mindset from one full of fear of what can 'go wrong' into one that expects birth to 'go right' (whatever that means). Feeling positive and confident at the start of labour can go a long way to helping the process along by keeping away from fight or flight and producing lots of oxytocin.

It's learning decision making tools- Knowing your rights when it comes to birth (psst, you can pretty much do what you want) and knowing how and where to get all the information you need, helps you to feel informed and confident in making the decisions needed to birth your baby. This may be during pregnancy, by getting information from third parties such as AIMS or doing your own research. It may be during labour, in which case using decision making tools designed to get as much information about your circumstances will help you to make decisions about your care. Just knowing the questions to ask to find out if it's safe to take 30 mins to make your decision can make a huge difference. Nobody wants to make a decision in a rush when some time could have been taken to process it and ensure the choices were understood and considered and the best one for the family chosen!

It's the hypnobirthing tools you've probably heard about- Last but not least there are the famous hypnobirthing tools, what comes to mind when people say hypnobirthing (aside from swinging clocks and vagina whispering). These tools are an incredible way to prepare for birth and remain calm and comfortable throughout. However, on their own without all the stuff above, they're not enough. Add these into your routine alongside all the information and mindset stuff and you have got this!

Breathing Techniques- These ensure you're taking lots of nice big even breaths throughout your labour to keep the oxygen flowing nicely, this will help your uterus to be able to do it's job as efficiently and comfortably as possible. They are also a great way of distracting you from what's going on around you and giving you something else to focus on.

It sounds simple but breathing techniques can do so much to keep you calm and if you practice them during pregnancy you will feel the benefit on the day.

Visualisation– This is a way to almost practise birth before its time to do it for real. Thinking in your head about how you'd like your birth to go or saying it out loud, can help you to feel more confident in your plans and trick your mind into thinking it's nothing new when labour starts for real! This can help reduce the chance of entering fight or flight and keep oxytocin flowing!

Affirmations– Using the law of repetition, you can convince your brain to believe something just by showing it the same information repeatedly. Instead of talking about how you DON'T want labour to go, write affirmations and say things about how you DO want it to go. Giving your brain a bit of cheerleading can help it to believe in you! Instead of saying 'I don't want to tear' say 'my body WILL stretch to accommodate my baby'. After a while the affirmations sink into your subconscious and help you to have confidence in yourself which in turn will help you feel more relaxed and encourage the hormones needed for labour.

Relaxation– As humans living in a world full of things to do, technology etc. we rarely spend time relaxing and doing absolutely nothing! This means that our neocortex, the part of our brain responsible for rational thinking, is almost never switched off. We very much want that part of the brain to be out of the way during labour and not interfering with the process by thinking of unhelpful scenarios! By practising relaxation during pregnancy, you can make it easier to relax on cue, a skill that's very handy for labour! Try lying back and doing absolutely nothing, on the sofa, in bed or in the bath, wherever you like! If you find it difficult to switch off then doing something that doesn't require much thought counts too! Colouring in, knitting/ crochet, walking in nature etc. may be more your thing. Do what works for you!

Hypnobirthing tracks– Listening to hypnobirthing tracks will help you to relax, they are usually written by hypnotherapists and therefore help to induce a state of calm and relaxation. The words will also provide you with lots of encouragement and self belief as they talk you through how amazing you and your body are. Don't worry if you fall asleep listening to them, they will still be going into your subconscious even if you're not actively listening. Just be sure you don't listen when driving or operating heavy machinery as this is not safe. It's fine to listen to affirmation tracks anytime though for that little boost of confidence!

Anchoring– Whilst you are practising relaxation you can help by setting up cues for your brain to associate with relaxation and therefore help you to do it whenever you want, these are called anchors. Anchors can help you to incorporate all 5 senses and therefore make the conditions seem the same wherever you are. You may spray a room spray or have an essential oil that you use whilst relaxing that you then use in labour, you may have a blanket or cushion that you have with you whilst relaxing that you can have with you in your birth space or you may use your hypnobirthing tracks or relaxing music to aid your relaxation, then you can use this during labour and it will all help you to relax despite other things being different such as the location (or the fact you're in labour eek!).

TOP TIP– Use all the hypnobirthing tools at once throughout your pregnancy and in labour and see how chilled you can feel!

hypnobirthing for caesarean?

Hypnobirthing can be incredibly useful even for a caesarean birth, whether planned or unplanned. Many people assume hypnobirthing is only for natural labour, but its tools are just as effective in surgery — for reducing fear, stress, and tension, and for creating a more calm, empowered experience. How?

1. Reduces Fear and Anxiety

Fear and tension increase pain perception, blood pressure, and stress hormones. Hypnobirthing teaches techniques such as deep breathing, visualisation, and positive affirmations calm your nervous system. Even in a caesarean theatre, these tools help you stay grounded, relaxed, and in control of your emotional state.

2. Enhances Focus and Presence

Hypnobirthing teaches you to tune inward and focus on the birth you want, rather than feeling swept along by events. In a caesarean, this can help you remain mentally present for meeting your baby, communicating your needs to the surgical team, and noticing those special first moments.

3. Supports Relaxed Muscle Tone

Tension can make anaesthesia less effective and slow recovery. Hypnobirthing techniques like guided visualisations and progressive relaxation help keep muscles soft and relaxed, making the surgery physically easier and more comfortable.

4. Prepares Your Mind for the Unexpected

Even if your caesarean is planned, surgery can still feel unpredictable. Hypnobirthing encourages mental flexibility: imagining different scenarios, reinforcing positive outcomes, and creating calm responses for surprises. This can reduce fear if things change last minute.

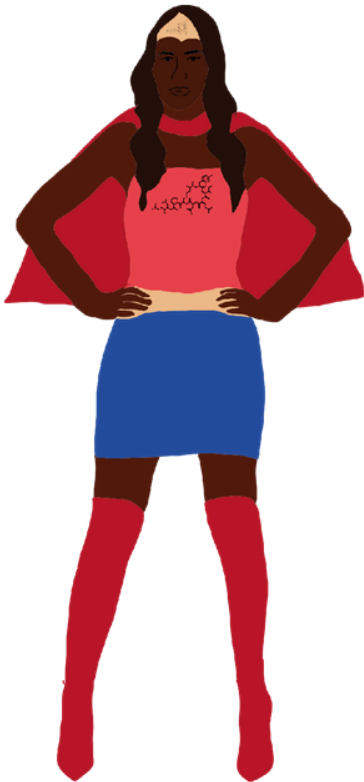
5. Improves Bonding and Birth Satisfaction

A calm, relaxed birth fosters oxytocin release, even in surgery. Using hypnobirthing techniques during your caesarean can enhance your connection with your baby, support skin to skin and early breastfeeding, and help you feel emotionally present rather than detached.

6. Empowers You and Your Birth Partner

Hypnobirthing isn't just about relaxation; it's about knowledge, agency, and teamwork. Your birth partner can learn scripts, breathing techniques, and visualisations to support you, advocate for your preferences, and create a calm, safe environment for both of you.

hormones – the birth heroes



Oxytocin– The Ultimate badass

Powers– Fills you with love, makes you feel euphoric, contracts your uterus, tells your breasts to release milk, bonds you to baby. It can do all of this in pregnancy, during labour/birth and after!

Where to find– Anywhere there's laughter, love, snuggles, massage, nipple/clitoral stimulation and all the good stuff! Try some chocolate and a funny movie!

Weaknesses– Hates being observed, being around strangers and unfamiliar places. VERY shy.

Everybody loves Oxytocin (except that pesky adrenaline), you want to encourage Oxytocin to show her face as much as you can!

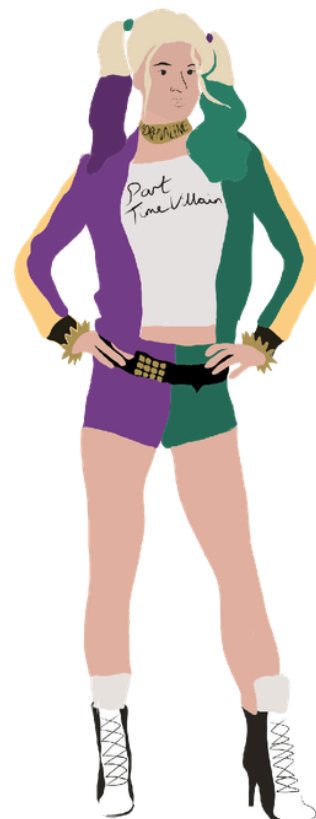
Adrenaline– The Part Time Villain

Powers– Makes you alert, blocks oxytocin, increases heart rate and gets ready for fight or flight.

Where to find– In places with fear or anxiety, and at the end of labour where she decides to do some good! Love her or hate her she has her uses and she's not always evil!

Weaknesses– Can't help but get involved when they think you're not feeling safe and calm.

Uh Oh! When it's not the right time, it's presence will slow or stop birth making the process longer and less comfortable.



hormones – the birth heroes



Melatonin- The Sidekick

Powers- Uses the power of darkness to boost her friend Oxytocin and help labour and bonding along.

Where to find- In quiet dark spaces with privacy. At night, when the hustle and bustle of the day has ended.

Weaknesses- Hates bright lights, screens and being watched.

TIP- Switch off the lights/ phones in your birth space!

Endorphins- The Life of the party

Powers- Can give you a buzz, a dose of pain relief 200x stronger than morphine. Makes you feel calm and in control.

Where to find- Brought on by physical contact and massage/TENS Machine. Encouraged by love and laughter.

TIP- Encourage endorphins in early labour and save them for later!



How might you amend your birth space knowing about these?

Relaxin- Ms Stretch

Powers- Makes your body bendy and flexible to help your pelvis open up to accommodate baby. Does the same for baby to help you both work together smoothly.

Where to find- All over your body throughout pregnancy!

Weaknesses- Can unfortunately lead to injury during pregnancy as things stretch a little further than usual, be careful not to lift anything too heavy!



Prolactin- The Nurturing Protector

Powers- Brain washes you to want to care for your baby no matter how tired you are, no matter what they need. Compliments oxytocin and aids bonding with baby. Encourages your body to make milk for baby.

Where to find- At its strongest at the point of birth and just after. Also during the night whilst breastfeeding.

Prostaglandins- The Hidden Helper

Powers- Softens your cervix and can bring on surges.

Where to find- Around an irritated cervix and hiding in semen!

HINT- This is what sweeps are aiming to stimulate and what is found in a synthetic form in some types of induction methods.



caesarean birth

Hopefully this will help you to become more familiar with the process of caesarean. Caesareans obviously happen for various reasons and it is not always known that that is going to be the mode of birth, in this case, the pre op appointment below would not happen and the preparation on the day may vary a little but many of the info is relevant to various scenarios.

Pre Op

If a caesarean is planned, either booked for a certain date or for when labour begins, there'll be a pre op appointment beforehand in order to make sure the birther and the medical team are as prepared as possible. At this appointment there is a usual antenatal check, listening in to baby, blood pressure, urine dipstick etc. There is a blood test for iron levels and there is talk about anaesthetic, the birther may be weighed if they are happy to be.

On the day of an elective caesarean

On the day of a planned caesarean, the birther will be asked to fast. The length of time will vary based on the local policy. The birther will be asked to thoroughly wash their body and hair with a disinfectant wash prior to coming in. They will go into the hospital first thing in the morning. Once there they will have another antenatal check and be given a gown and surgical socks to put on. The birther will be given an antacid to prevent aspiration during surgery. There is likely to be a tremendous wait depending on who is in need of the theatre and team that day. It's a great idea for people to expect a long wait so that they will not be disappointed. The order will always be based on who is in most need and what is safest for everyone. Usually elective caesareans are less urgent than those who have been in labour and now require a caesarean.

Relevant to most caesareans

Once ready, the birther will be greeted by the team who will be caring for them that day. This will consist of 2 surgeons, a scrub nurse, anaesthetist and an operating department practitioner (assistant to the anaesthetist). The birther will receive their anaesthetic and the anaesthetist will remain by the birthers head throughout checking to see that all is well with them. The surgeon will test the site to check that it is numb and if so, they will proceed with the caesarean. The baby will be born within the first 10 minutes and the whole process will take about an hour including removing the placenta and stitching everything back together. After this the birther and their partner will be moved to a recovery room nearby for observations before being moved to the postnatal ward.

Options

There are many different options when it comes to caesareans despite what is commonly thought. There are lots of different things that can be chosen in order for each birther to have a caesarean that they are happy with in most cases.

- If there is no urgent need for baby to be born then there is the option for baby to be born slowly and gently to mimic vaginal birth in that the baby is squeezed by the incision and this can help to clear the baby's airways of fluid.
- The birther may wish to have their ECG dots on their back so that their chest is clear for skin to skin after the birth.
- You can choose which hand their IV goes into so that it is not in the way as much.
- You can have the screen lowered to be able to watch baby enter the world, due to the bump and the angle of the birther they will be unable to see the incision but can see the baby as they are born.
- You can opt to have the surgeon talk them through what's happening at each point, some people find it comforting to know and others don't want to know at all.
- You can request optimal cord clamping which should now be standard after all births where possible but it is always a good idea to add it to a birth plan.
- Skin to skin should be standard and birth partners can help to facilitate this if the birther finds it difficult to do this for themselves.

Ways to remain calm in the lead up to a caesarean

Whether you have weeks, days, hours or less to prepare for your caesarean, there are various things you can do that may help you to feel calm.

- If you would like, you could watch positive caesarean videos, concentrate on the face of the birther as they meet their baby. Sometimes it's the unknown that is scary so just seeing what the process is can make it seem less so.
- Listening to MP3s and using breathing techniques whilst travelling to the hospital and during any periods of waiting can really help to keep the oxytocin flowing and the adrenaline at bay, making it feel much more positive.
- Making sure expectations are managed can help prevent panic on the day, it is likely that there will be a big wait before a caesarean and this could even mean that the date the caesarean takes place is not the date it was booked for, this can be really disappointing or shocking if unexpected.

Notes:

Post caesarean tips

- Pressing a clean muslin, sanitary pad etc against the scar whilst coughing, sneezing or having a poo can help it to feel more protected. But also just to ease any soreness or itchiness.
- Get lots of rest, live upstairs for a couple of days to allow yourself to rest as much as possible- whatever works for you.
- If going up and down stairs- use a CRAB WALK
- Keep lots of water around the house to keep hydrated, one either side of the bed to reduce twisting and reaching too.
- Place a stool near to the bed to help you get out each morning etc, this will reduce the pressure you feel in your scar.
- Chewing gum or drinking mint tea can help with any trapped wind which can make for a lot of discomfort after a caesarean.
- It's advised to keep on top of pain relief in the first few days even if you feel comfortable when pain relief is due. Once the pain relief wears off it is harder to get on top of the discomfort and so it will be more comfortable to take pain relief at the suggested intervals just in case to start with. – write this down!
- Keep visitors to a minimum initially and prioritise your postpartum recovery- show your baby off when you're feeling ready and comfortable to do so.
- Wear loose comfortable clothing, make sure your clothing doesn't rub and irritate your wound. Keep it dry too.
- Clean your wound regularly with warm water and pat dry
- Have a basket of snacks, tv remote, water, pain relief phone and charger near you

Notes:

building a positive mindset

So we know how fear of birth can affect the body physically during the birthing process, now let's look at all the things we can do in pregnancy to add positive information about birth to our subconscious and change our mindset around birth!

We take in negative thoughts on birth from what we see or hear. TV shows, movies and documentaries are a huge reason that many people fear birth. Along with horror stories from friends and family and unhelpful headlines in the media, it's not surprising that most people are not looking forward to birthing their baby!

What can we do to change our mindset into a positive one instead?

Write down all the things you can think of and then make sure to start using them to make you feel informed and excited to birth your baby.

What are you looking forward to?



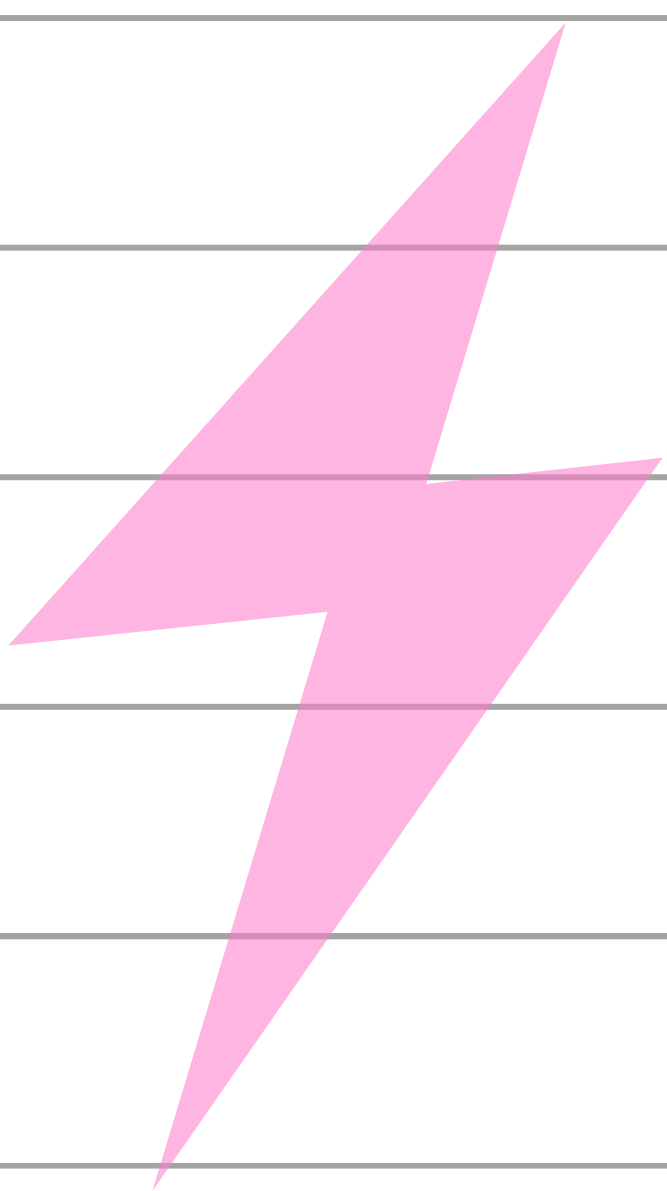
now lets work on those worries

The way we feel about birth physically impacts the way our body births. So here is a space in which you can start to let go of some of those fears.

1. List all of the things that you are worried about, the things that come up when you think of birth below. Let's get this stuff of your chest and out of your mind!
2. Once you've written them down give them a rating of 1 - 5. 1 being less worried and 5 being most worried.
3. Have your partner do the same.
4. Now look at your lists together and discuss what you can do to help yourself feel less concerned about your worries. What can you do to take the 5's - 1's.

Once you have completed this, take some time to relax and listen to your 'Fear Release' MP3. You should listen to this track from this point onwards whenever you feel any of these concerns creeping back or if you feel you want to release any new worries.

Worries or Concerns	Rating 1-5



writing your own affirmations

Affirmations are sentences created to affect the conscious and the subconscious mind so that in turn, they affect our behaviour, thinking patterns, habits, and environment. The words composing the affirmation, automatically and involuntarily, bring up related mental images into the mind, which inspire, energize and motivate. The affirmations and the resultant mental images get engraved on the subconscious mind, which in turn, changes the behaviour, habits, actions, and reactions according to the repeated words.

Example: I'm worried about how I will handle the contractions becomes "I surrender to the rhythm of birth, knowing I am capable of handling each moment gracefully"

What is your worry or concern?

Your positive affirmation

What is your worry or concern?

Your positive affirmation

What is your worry or concern?

Your positive affirmation



visualisation activity

Use these activities to get a feel for how visualisation can feel! Please don't worry if you don't nail it the first time! Practise makes perfect! You can spend time visualising your positive birth as often as you like, it's a fab way to change your mindset and send oxytocin to your baby!

1. First you can have a partner or friend listen to you for 5 mins (or record) telling your birth story as if it's already happened. Tell it in as much detail as possible, how did you feel? Who was there? Where were you? What happened when? Make it as positive as you like, this is supposed to be YOUR perfect birth. If you would like to complete this activity alone, just set a timer and get chatting. Go with the flow and see what amazing birth story you can come up with and imagine it's yours! How do you feel now? A bit silly? That's alright! Do you feel motivated to go and get that birth you were just visualising? Go and get it!

2. Write your birth story in the past tense, this can be done as well as the previous activity to see which one you prefer! Some people don't find it easy to visualise. Read through your finished story and see how you feel! Does it make you feel like your birth could be as positive as that? Are you feeling really pumped about it? It's working!

3, Create a vision board to help you based on the key points from your story (e.g., fairy lights, birth pool, your partner etc.

Notes:



practice schedule

All these new tools, breathing techniques and MP3s can seem a bit daunting to start with. Here's an idea of when you might use each one throughout pregnancy, during the birth and beyond!

- Breathing techniques- practise these for 5 mins daily until you can do each one easily without thinking, this will make them easier to use on demand when you need them.
- Chilled Out Breathing- In for 4, out for 4. Do this for at least 3 minutes for it to take effect but keep it up as long as you want! Use this anytime you feel anxious, stressed or panicked. This could be anything at all, you really can't use this too much so if in doubt, try it out! It's super handy for on the journey to or whilst waiting for antenatal appointments and scans.
- Wave Breathing- In for 7, out for 7. This is all about making sure you are breathing in nice and deeply and steadily. It can give you something to focus on during birth and ensure you're getting plenty of oxygen.

This is a rough idea of when you might find them useful but please do listen to the ones that suit you best when you fancy it! The idea is to use them regularly to chill out and then make it more and more easy for you to relax on cue, very helpful in labour! Do remember that you don't have to be awake or actively listening to each one for it to have an effect. Do not listen whilst driving.

- TBU Relaxation-

This is a general relaxation track which is useful to birthers and birth partners alike! It's useful to listen to this one daily to get you used to using it to relax. You may find that if you pop it on as you go to bed, you start falling asleep closer and closer to the beginning!

- Caesarean birth

This should be used once or twice a week throughout pregnancy to help you visualise your birth and have positive thoughts around birth. Take those with you on the day! You can then, as your estimated due date approaches or if you go post-dates, increase this to daily where possible.

- TBU Confidence-

Use this a couple of times a week throughout pregnancy for a confidence boost. It can be used more often if you feel it would help. It may be useful before antenatal appointments to give you confidence to speak up for what you want!

- TBU Fear Release-

Use this together with your birth partner as early on as possible in pregnancy to help ease any fears about birth.

tailoring your birth environment

Fairy Lights LED candles – Create mood lighting to promote melatonin and give a bit of a magical feel

A nice big towel or two– More comfortable than hospital ones.

A comfy blanket and pillow from home– more comfortable and make you feel more at home.

Facecloth– Used with warm or cold water to provide comfort and relief during labour.

Face Spray mist– Can be cooling and comforting during labour if birther is feeling hot.

Photos of loved ones/ pets/ special times – Helps promote oxytocin.

Playlist of music– Happy cheesy music to get you dancing to promote oxytocin. Or background music to promote relaxation.

MP3s– Help to stay calm and promote relaxation.

Portable fan– Can help to keep cool.

Massage oil– For massage techniques, promote oxytocin and endorphins.

Essential oil– Aid relaxation if it is one that is used at home or during relaxation.

Portable blackout blind– Helps block out light and aid melatonin.

Eye mask– Keeps the birther in the dark for melatonin and help to stay in their zone on the journey.

Sweets/sugary snack– Raise blood sugar and keep energy levels up.

Fluffy socks– Keep feet warm when all your blood is directed to uterus.

Affirmations– Boost of confidence, a reminder of how strong the birther is etc.

Head massager– Can help to keep them distracted, produce oxytocin and endorphins.

Baby clothes/comforter– Helps to boost oxytocin, reminder that baby will arrive soon, reminder of how small baby is.

use your brain

The BRAIN acronym is an important decision making tool that everyone should know when accessing maternity care. It can be used to make decisions regarding scans, treatment, monitoring, tests, interventions and birth plans.

Having this tool and using it alongside your own research into your options and each one can transform the way you feel about it all. Knowing exactly why something is offered, what other options there are and all about it makes it a totally different experience to feeling confused and out of control and not able to be confident in your decisions. You are in charge here and when you have all the information you need you are able to make the decisions that are best for you. You've got this!

Benefits

Find out the benefits of what's being offered, whether it's a test, scan, induction, caesarean or anything else. What is the aim here? What will it achieve? WHY is it being offered? Is it 'just in case' or is there a known reason to do it in your case specifically or is that just policy? For example an induction may be suggested due to the birthing parents age as that's what the policy is there.

Risks

What are the risks of doing what is offered? How safe is it for you? How safe is it for baby? Does it increase the chance of needing any other tests, treatments or interventions? For example, if an induction is suggested due to baby or parent being unwell, what are the risks relating to their condition, how well are they expected to cope?

Alternatives

Is there anything that could be offered instead? Instead of an induction is there monitoring that could be done? Is there another form that a test or procedure could take? Daily bloody glucose monitoring at home instead of a Glucose Tolerance Test at hospital etc. A different medication for a condition etc. When you know what all the options are then you can get informed on them all and make your choice.

Instincts

What does your instinct tell you about it? Instinct is a really important thing to consider in pregnancy, birth and parenthood. Often the parent will know that something is not ok with baby before health professionals do. Similarly, they will often feel that all is well with baby despite a professional believing otherwise. So what do you think? What is your gut feeling? Do you feel like all is well and you're happy to continue as you are or do you think what is offered might be necessary? Does it make you feel relieved to think about getting answers or baby being born asap? Or does it all feel too hasty?

Nothing

What happens if you do nothing instead? Not what's being offered, not an alternative, just nothing. What is expected to happen then? Is it nothing? Is there a small chance of something? Or is there a big chance of something occurring? It may be that you do nothing for an hour, a day a week or maybe just nothing at all as long as all is well. It's completely up to you.

Bonus one-

Know that no matter what the circumstances, you are the decision maker here. Nothing can be done without your consent and in the vast majority of cases there is time to take some time to decide, even if it's just 10 minutes. You can think this through, do your research and make your choice. If anything goes ahead it is because you've decided that it's the best thing for you and your baby! Remember a positive birth is possible. A positive birth is not a spontaneous intervention free vaginal birth or even a vaginal birth at all. Take some time to destress, practise breathing techniques, sit on it for a while if you can and then research to help you make your decision. Don't worry about what anyone else would choose, just pick what's right for you.

Questions for birth team:



birth planning

Firstly, planning a caesarean is NOT “overthinking”, “pointless”, or something that only matters for vaginal births.

Anyone who thinks that simply hasn’t yet realised how powerful and personal a caesarean birth can be.

A caesarean is not just a medical procedure, it is still your baby’s birth.

And just like any birth, it deserves intention, understanding, and choice.

A caesarean birth plan is not a rigid script or a list of demands.

It’s simply a clear way of expressing what matters to you, what helps you feel safe, and how you would like your baby to arrive into the world.

It helps your care providers understand your preferences without you needing to explain everything in the middle of surgery.

But even more importantly, it helps YOU and your birth partner truly understand your options, feel prepared, and feel emotionally connected to the experience.

Many people are surprised to learn how many choices still exist within a caesarean birth.

Things like:

- The atmosphere in theatre
- Music, lighting, and language used
- Whether you can see your baby being born
- Delayed cord clamping
- Immediate skin-to-skin
- Your partner’s role
- How communication happens during surgery

Most people have never heard of a “gentle caesarean” or assumed that surgery means they have no say.

Exploring these options is often the first moment people realise:

“Oh... I actually can shape this experience.”

Just like with any birth plan, the goal isn’t to control everything — it’s to understand what’s possible.

Even if you are planning a caesarean, circumstances can still change:

- Planned caesarean → earlier emergency caesarean
- Caesarean → labour starting before surgery
- Calm theatre → more urgent situation
- You → baby needing extra support

So it’s helpful to think in scenarios.

For example:

- Plan A: Your ideal planned caesarean experience
- Plan B: If labour starts before surgery
- Plan C: If the caesarean becomes urgent or more medicalised

Before you think about limitations, policies, or “what they’ll allow”, start with imagination.

birth planning

Ask yourself:

- What kind of birth experience feels calm and safe to me?
- How do I want to feel in the operating theatre?
- How do I want to meet my baby?
- What would make this feel emotional, not just clinical?
- What role do I want my partner to play?

At this stage, nothing is too unrealistic or too idealistic.

You are not negotiating yet — you are dreaming.

Because once you know what you want, you can explore how to move towards it, what compromises exist, and what alternatives are available.

And that is where real empowerment begins.

Without a plan, a caesarean can feel like something that happens to you.

With a plan, it becomes something you are actively part of.

Planning does not guarantee a perfect birth.

But it dramatically increases the chances that you will feel:

- informed
- respected
- connected
- emotionally present
- proud of your birth

And that is just as important as the medical outcome.

Start with understanding why you're having a caesarean and what flexibility exists.

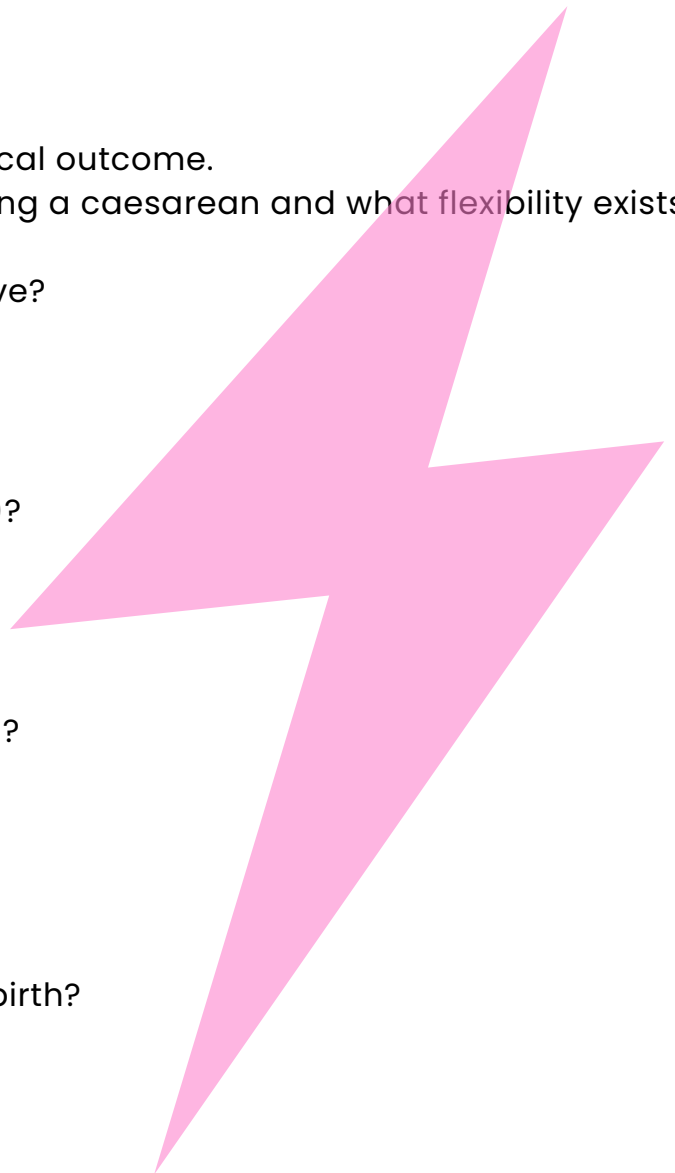
Reflect on:

- Is it planned, recommended, or elective?

- What are the medical reasons (if any)?

- What choices are still available to you?

- What matters most to you about the birth?



So below is an example to help you and some bullet points to help you plan your own on the template!

Notes to Midwife

- Anything important you'd like your midwife and team to know about you.
- Fears, anxieties, or triggers.
- What helps you feel calm and safe.
- How you prefer to be spoken to.
- Anything you strongly want or want to avoid.

Environment

- Calm, quiet atmosphere where possible.
- Music or playlist.
- Dimmed lights if safe.
- Minimal non-essential conversation.
- Partner and/or support person present throughout.
- Gentle, respectful language from staff.

Preferred Anaesthetic

- Understanding what type of anaesthetic will be used (usually spinal).
- Being informed about sensations you may feel.
- Preferences around anti-nausea medication or comfort measures.

Monitoring

- Explanation of monitoring equipment.
- Which hand for cannula and where ECG are placed.
- Partner being informed if you are unable to focus.

Prior to Birth

- Quiet moment with your partner before surgery begins.
- Clear explanation of what will happen next.
- Opportunity to ask last questions.
- Grounding techniques, breathing, or affirmations.

During Birth

- Step-by-step communication about what is happening.
- Lowered drape or clear drape.
- Partner announcing the birth.
- Photos or video.
- Slow or "gentle" caesarean.

Catching Baby

- Possibility of you or your partner seeing or "catching" baby if appropriate and safe.
- Baby brought to your chest as soon as possible.
- Partner staying close to you and baby.
- Respectful handling of baby.

Third Stage (Birth of the Placenta)

- Explanation of what is happening.
- Delayed cord clamping.
- Partner cutting the cord if desired.
- Option to see the placenta if meaningful to you.

In Recovery

- Skin-to-skin contact as soon as possible.
- Partner staying with baby at all times.
- Quiet, calm recovery space if available.
- Support with first feed.
- Clear communication about your condition and baby's wellbeing.

Golden Hour

- Uninterrupted time with your baby where possible.
- Delayed routine procedures.
- Skin-to-skin and bonding prioritised.
- First feed without pressure or rush.
- Minimal staff interruptions where appropriate.

Notes

- Anything else that matters deeply to you.
- Cultural, spiritual, or personal preferences.
- Feeding intentions.
- Visitor preferences.
- Top priorities if plans change.
- One sentence that captures what you want most from this birth.



CAESAREAN

birth proposal

NOTES TO MIDWIFE

- Birth Partner: ****
- Known baby girl
- Doula: Leanne
- Second baby

ENVIRONMENT

- No talking/communication during the actual birth
- Aromatherapy tissue
- Music playing on my phone next to my head
- Only essential people present as discussed
- Calming touch from Charlie
- Eye mask to shut off

PREFERRED ANAESTHETIC

Preference is to be awake with a spinal block as discussed.

MONITORING

- ECG placed on my back please for easy skin to skin.
- Cannula in the left hand.

PRIOR TO BIRTH

- Calm environment with relaxation music playing
- I'd like low lighting and aromatherapy for relaxation.
- **** and Leanne to remain with me at all times.
- Keep me distracted and help my anxiety (film, games etc)
- Keep me calm.

DURING THE BIRTH

- **** and Leanne to remain with me throughout.
- I want a gentle and slow caesarean.
- My music playing next to my head.
- Keep as quiet as possible when our baby is being born.
- Leanne to take lots of pictures and videos once baby is coming out.

Name: ***
Pronoun: She/Her

Birth partner name: ***
Pronoun: He/Him
Number:



CAESAREAN

birth proposal

CATCHING THE BABY

- I want one arm out of my gown to receive my baby to my chest for skin to skin and have this uninterrupted.
- I do not want my baby to be cleaned before receiving them on my chest.

3RD STAGE

- I want a LOTUS BIRTH where medical issues allow and would like to wait for white.
- Please keep the placenta attached until we are ready to cut the cord in recovery. This will be our first opportunity to do so.
- Baby girl can be brought to me once the placenta has been removed and placed in a pot next to me.
- We are discarding our placenta.

DURING RECOVERY

- Wait until I am in recovery for weighing baby.
- *** to cut the cord in recovery.
- I wish to start my breastfeeding journey as peacefully as possible.
- Vitamin K via injection
- I consent to NIPE check, as many baby assessments as possible on me.

GOLDEN HOUR

- At least one full hour, as undisturbed as possible.
- Skin to skin for at least one hour.
- Do not want my baby to have a hat in theatre. We can use our own in recovery if needed
- *** to have skin to skin after me

NOTES

Previous psychosis post birth. I struggle with anxiety and may panic, I am under Perinatal mental health team. Leanne and *** are my support and are to stay with me at all times.

We have requested a private room because of this.

Pre-eclampsia in labour with previous pregnancy.

Medications:

Antenatal aspirin until 36 weeks

No allergies.

No crowns.

No piercings.



CAESAREAN

birth proposal

NOTES TO MIDWIFE

ENVIRONMENT

PREFERRED ANAESTHETIC

MONITORING

PRIOR TO BIRTH

DURING THE BIRTH

Name:
Pronoun:

Birth partner name:
Pronoun:
Number:



CAESAREAN

birth proposal

CATCHING THE BABY

3RD STAGE

DURING RECOVERY

GOLDEN HOUR

NOTES

postnatal expectations/planning

So much time and energy is spent preparing for birth, yet the days and weeks after birth—the fourth trimester—are where families often need the most support. This is a time of profound transition, when your baby is adjusting to life outside the womb and you are adjusting to life as a parent.

Your newborn's needs are simple but intense: closeness, warmth, feeding, and responsive care. Frequent waking, cluster feeding, and a strong desire to be held are not signs of “bad habits”—they are normal, biologically driven behaviours that help your baby feel safe and secure. Planning ahead for these realities can make the early weeks feel less overwhelming and more supported.

At the same time, your body and mind are undergoing enormous change. Hormones shift rapidly after birth, which can affect your emotions, energy levels, and sense of identity. Feeling tearful, sensitive, euphoric, anxious, or unsure at times is common—and you are not alone. Preparing for this emotional landscape, alongside practical needs like meals, rest, feeding support, and household help, can create a softer landing into parenthood.

Postpartum planning is not about perfection—it's about permission: permission to rest, to ask for help, to move slowly, and to prioritise connection over productivity. By thinking ahead about support, boundaries, and nourishment—both physical and emotional—you give yourself and your baby the best possible start in this tender, transformative season.

Research consistently shows that practical support, emotional validation, and realistic expectations significantly improve parental wellbeing and reduce the risk of postnatal anxiety and depression. Preparing for the fourth trimester is one of the most powerful ways to care for yourself and your baby.

Key themes:

- Talk openly about how life might change after birth.
- Normalise feelings of uncertainty, grief for old routines, or identity shifts.
- Create space for connection, not perfection.

Becoming a parent is a major psychological transition. Mixed emotions are normal—even when a baby is deeply wanted and loved.

postnatal expectations/planning

After pains

The cramps known as afterbirth pains, or simply afterpains, are caused by contractions of your uterus as it returns to its pre-pregnancy size after you have your baby, and expels any clots. (This process is called "involution.")

This can intensify when feeding, but is not usually something to be concerned about, and is often more common after subsequent births. Taking paracetamol or ibuprofen is safe and can help.

Bleeding (AKA Lochia)

It usually begins straight after birth and can continue for up to six weeks postpartum; however, the heaviest flow tends to be during the first two weeks. you may find clots, anything bigger than a 50p should be monitored and anything bigger than your palm should be checked. Between around days four and 10, lochia should get lighter and have a more pinkish or brownish hue. This will still happen following a caesarean.

Never use a tampon!

Swelling

You may experience some vaginal swelling as well as swelling to your vulva. This is quite common, and usually reduces after 2-3 days.

Use 'padsickles' (maternity pad, soaked in aloe and witch hazel and popped into the freezer) to help, plus arnica to reduce any bruising.

Other areas may still have excess water, but this too should reduce in a couple of weeks!

Stitches

If you've had stitches after tearing or an episiotomy, keep them clean by bathing daily, to help prevent infection. Use plain warm water then carefully pat yourself dry. If your stitches are sore or uncomfortable, tell your midwife.

Stitches usually dissolve themselves, but sometimes they have to be taken out- check with your midwife.

Using a Peribottle (or just a jug of warm water) may help reduce any stinging also.

Baby blues

Are due to a sudden drop of hormones, which your body tries to process over the first few days post birth.

Symptoms of baby blues include: feeling emotional, irrational or overwhelmed, tearful (without knowing why), irritable and moody and down or anxious. They usually pass, but if you find they're sticking around, seek support from your midwife or other agencies including PANDAS.

Colostrum

Colostrum is a highly concentrated form of breast milk and is what your breast/chest produces in the first few days after your baby being born. Because it's so concentrated, colostrum often has a thick consistency, and a golden yellow colour.

Colostrum contains high levels of fat, protein and carbohydrates, so your baby will be able to get plenty of nutrition even from the small quantities you produce.*liquidgold*

Going to the loo

You might be shitting yourself (excuse the pun) at the thought of going to the loo post birth.

Try not to hold it, your bladder may have lower levels of control, so go as soon as you feel it. Drink lots to dilute the urine too.

You probably won't have a poo for a few days after the birth, but it's important not to let yourself get constipated. Eat lots of fibre and drink lots of water to help keep your stools soft, occasionally a laxative may be helpful. (p.s. its very unliely your stutches will burst).

Piles

Piles can be quite common (yes I had them).

Try not to push or strain when going to the toilet to help prevent and use 'Anusol' or similar to help the discomfort of they happen. They usually go away within a few days. Be aware of your diet to help your stolls stay soft too.

Night Sweats

Postpartum sweating and night sweats are very common and normal, and they usually go away after a few weeks. Strategies that can help include drinking plenty of water to prevent dehydration, and taking a lukewarm or cool shower before bed

Any questions or if you want any support, always contact me and I can signpost/support you if necessary.



postnatal plan

SOCIAL SUPPORT: WHO CAN PROVIDE YOU SOCIAL SUPPORT? FAMILY, FRIENDS, NEIGHBOURS, DOULAS, OR ONLINE?

- *** parents
- Antenatal group
- Leanne
- Peanut App
- (visits, texts, calls, baby groups etc.)
- Night feeding!

REST: HOW WILL YOU MAKE SURE YOU GET ENOUGH REST? HELP WITH HOUSEHOLD, VISITORS, NAPS, RELAXATION TECHNIQUES ETC?

- Lots of rest- *** to support between baby feeds.
- Leanne to support for rest.
- Cleaner/Dog walker to help
- *** parents - Cooks
- Ring doorbell? Door sign? Food drop off? Deliveries?
- Baths and rest, music to switch off, Insta scroll.
- Schedule naps.
- No visitors between 1-3 or after 6

EXAMPLE

FOOD: HOW WILL YOU MAKE SURE YOUR BODY IS NOURISHED? BATCH COOK, FOOD DELIVERIES, SUBSCRIPTIONS, SNACKS?

- Batch cooking
- Food vouchers
- Leanne support
- Snack basket (cereal bars, sweets, choc, bananas, dates, nuts)
- Smoothies
- Switch meals (main at lunch)

EMOTIONAL SUPPORT/SELF CARE: HOW WILL ENSURE YOUR RECOVERY PRIORITISES YOU, YOUR HEALING BODY, YOUR EMOTIONAL NEEDS, FRIENDS, FAMILY, PHYSIOTHERAPIST, MASSAGE TECHNIQUES, POSTNATAL SUPPORT?

- Self care: moving, walk around block, being outside, showers
- Do make up
- Postnatal support massage
- Leanne - postpartum yoga support.
- If want massage/hair etc, can use Leanne to support with baby etc.

Think about-

- You and your baby's immediate needs
- You and your baby's secondary needs

planning prompts

- Make a list of all the possible people that could come to support and help you get some rest after the birth.
- Explain ahead of time what you will be trying to achieve and ask for specific help from people. People love to help; they just don't know how to do it most times.
- Keep early afternoons free for napping, which is when most of us are at our sleepest.
- Make a note for the door to avoid being woken up during your nap or by unwanted visitors. Something like "New mother and baby sleeping, please don't knock or ring the doorbell, leave deliveries by the door/in this safe place/with neighbours/come back later".
- Try to rest. You may have heard the expression sleep when the baby sleeps there is some wisdom in it. If you cannot sleep, you could simply lie down and relax and/or listen to a relaxation track.
- Choose your supporters wisely, in that ideally, they should be both helpful and make you feel good. Having a bossy mother in law that irritates you isn't going to make for restful time. Nor is having a relative who expects to be waited upon. If you can afford it, consider hiring a postnatal doula. Or get family and friends to buy you doula vouchers. There are so many reasons for why this can be a game changer.
- Get your partner on board with your postnatal need for rest (if you have a partner). The first cause of conflict in couples after the birth of a baby is "who does what". Sit down with your partner, and separately write a list of all the chores and who does them. Then sit down and compare notes. Work together through what tasks can be dumped, outsourced, and taken on by the partner. The book "Baby's here! who does what?" by Duncan Fisher is a useful and easy to read resource.
- Plan for "one week in bed, one week around the bed/on the sofa".
- Batch cook and freeze food, ask for visitors to bring you homemade dishes, get some food delivered, stock up on nutritious snacks.
- Ask for gifts for yourself rather than the baby. This can include food deliveries, vouchers for a postnatal doula or a postnatal massage or bodywork, offers to come and look after your baby so you can sleep etc (check my post on Instagram/Facebook!)
- Think about who can hold/feed baby. What would you like?
- Plan for the unplanned. You might want to make sure that your plan includes possible curveballs, such as having a long induction or a caesarean, or if you and/or your baby need to stay in hospital for a while.
- Prepare for your emotional and physical needs (infection etc).

Ultimately, look after yourselves- RECOVER

- REST
- EAT
- CHORES
- OPTIONAL (If you prefer to go out and socialise, you can!)
- VISITORS
- EMOTIONAL
- RECEIVE



postnatal plan

SOCIAL SUPPORT: WHO CAN PROVIDE YOU SOCIAL SUPPORT? FAMILY, FRIENDS, NEIGHBOURS, DOULAS, OR ONLINE?

REST: HOW WILL YOU MAKE SURE YOU GET ENOUGH REST? HELP WITH HOUSEHOLD, VISITORS, NAPS, RELAXATION TECHNIQUES ETC?

FOOD: HOW WILL YOU MAKE SURE YOUR BODY IS NOURISHED? BATCH COOK, FOOD DELIVERIES, SUBSCRIPTIONS, SNACKS?

EMOTIONAL SUPPORT/SELF CARE: HOW WILL ENSURE YOUR RECOVERY PRIORITISES YOU, YOUR HEALING BODY, YOUR EMOTIONAL NEEDS, FRIENDS, FAMILY, PHYSIOTHERAPIST, MASSAGE TECHNIQUES, POSTNATAL SUPPORT?

Think about-

- You and your baby's immediate needs
- You and your baby's secondary needs

resources

books

- Birth After Caesarean (Keedle)
- Cesarean Section: Understanding & Celebrating Your Baby's Birth
- Choosing Cesarean
- Thinking Woman's Guide to a Better Birth (general evidence literacy)
- VBAC Handbook (Churchill)

podcasts

Caesarean Birth Focus

- The Uterine Sound Ep. 12 — Evidence-Based Cesarean Section
- Birth-ed Podcast — Cesarean Birth with Consultant Obstetrician Florence Wilcock
- Birth-ed Podcast — C-Section Recovery with Clare Bourne
- Birth-ed Podcast — VBAC with Dr Hazel Keedle (covers choices including caesarean)
- The Birth Uprising — Episode 25: Cesarean Birth with Anna
- The Birth Uprising — Episode 24: A Transformative Second Cesarean Birth

VBAC / After Caesarean Focus

- The Birth Uprising — Episode 18: To VBAC or Not To VBAC?
- The Birth Uprising — Episodes 3 & 4: Lucy's VBAC Journey (Parts 1 & 2)
- The Midwives' Cauldron — VBAC with Dr Hazel Keedle
- Evidence Based Birth® — EBB 113: The Evidence on VBAC
- Evidence Based Birth® — EBB 209: Unbiased VBAC Support with Jen Kamel
- True Birth Podcast — Episode 189: The VBAC Playbook
- The Great Birth Rebellion — Ep. 93: Vaginal Birth After Caesarean
- The Great Birth Rebellion — Ep. 157: VBAC Tips & Tricks

Reframing Birth Perspectives

- Dou-La-La — Episode 1: Does a Positive Birth Actually Exist? (includes discussion on caesarean being part of positive outcomes)

Notes: